Minnesota Exits and Entries Project: Spatial Analysis of Reentry

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INTRODUCTION

The Minnesota Exits and Entries Project asks why and how young adults prevail or fail in the community. This project examines US Census data to map patterns of reentry from prison, drug treatment, the county workhouse, foster care, military service, mental health treatment, and juvenile corrections. By geo-coding addresses for members of each population of interest, I provide readers with maps of reentry patterns and tables that allow statistical comparisons across the seven groups and 159 participants between the ages of 18 to 25.

PURPOSE OF RESEARCH

Countless individuals enter and exit institutions every day. To understand different dynamics of the cycle and ultimately prevent recidivism, The Minnesota Exits and Entries Project is examining how individual and community characteristics shape the likelihood of success. Scholars and policy makers are increasingly focused on the issue of "reentry" from institutions such as prison and drug treatment. My project asks where people go when they leave institutions. Specifically, do they return to neighborhoods with high rates of poverty and unemployment or to more advantaged communities? I examined data from the Minnesota Exits and Entry Project, mapping patterns of reentry from prison, drug treatment, county work houses, foster care, military service, mental health treatment, and juvenile corrections. Based on the existing literature, we hypothesize that those returning from prison will reenter to the least advantaged census tracts and those returning from military service will reenter to the most advantaged census tracts. My responsibility in this research is to critically analyze relocation patterns based on United States census data. The maps shown provide visual representation of reentry patterns in Minnesota, while the tables allow statistical comparisons across the seven groups.

METHODS

We used neighborhood characteristics to determine which domains are likely to return to certain neighborhoods. Averages were taken from the following:

- Population below poverty
- Median household income
- Population of renters
- Population of home owners
- Population of African American residents
- Population of White residents
- Population of Hispanic residents
- People age 25 and older with a high school diploma
- People age 25 and older with a college degree
- Employed
- Unemployed
- Married
- Female headed households

We accessed the census Fact Finder website, using the 2005-2009 American Community Survey 4-Year Estimates for Census Tracts. In order to configure this information, we then matched the coded numbers with the participants in each group to get a picture of the living conditions of their neighborhood. We also mapped the reentry patterns to show the spatial distribution of those leaving the institutions.

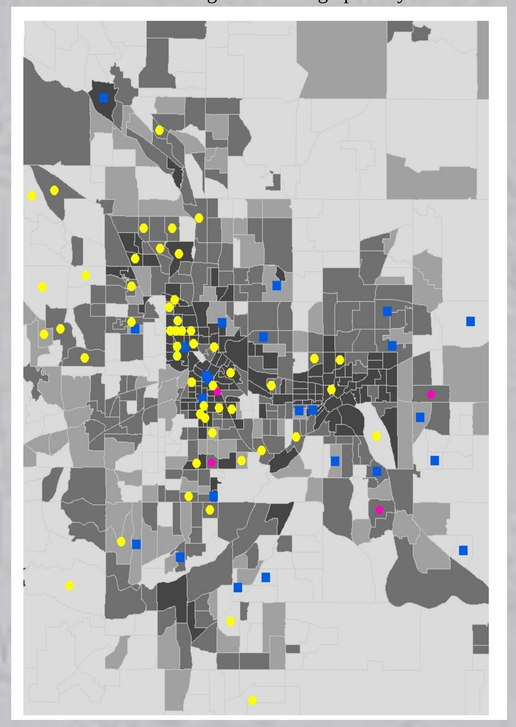
Data: 2005-2009 American Community Survey, US Census 2010.

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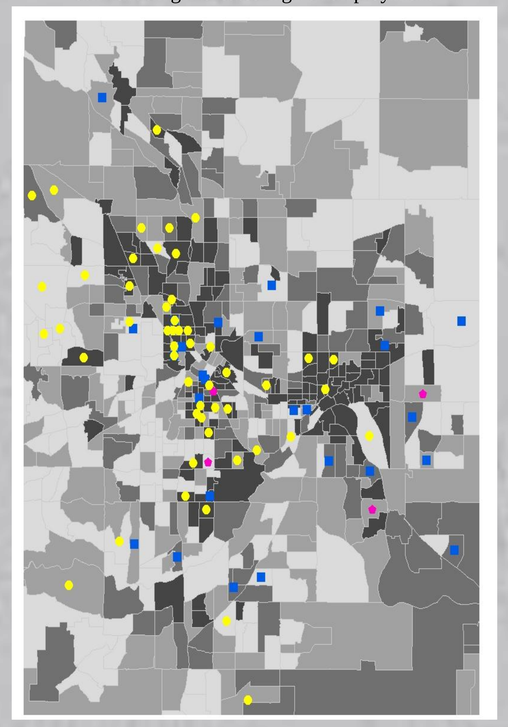
Special Acknowledgement to Sarah Shannon

RESULTS

Poverty Rate
dark shading indicates high poverty



Unemployment Rate
dark shading indicates high unemployment



Legend for Map

- Corrections (Adult Prison, Work House, Juvenile Corrections)
- Social Services (Foster Care, Chemical Dependency, Mental Health)
- National Guard
- Lowest quartile for poverty/unemployment
- Highest quartile for poverty/unemployment

Domain		%Below Poverty*	Median Household Income***	%Home Owners*	%Married Couple***
Adult Prison	Mean	16.3%	$45,260.28	66.0%	24.7%
	N	29	29	29	29
Chemical Dependency	Mean	17.1%	$50,347.96	59.5%	31.1%
	N	24	24	24	24
Foster Care	Mean	11.5%	$64,140.60	68.6%	25.4%
	N	10	10	10	10
Juvenile Corrections	Mean	20.3%	$47,328.87	62.9%	28.9%
	N	46	46	46	46
Mental Health	Mean	10.2	$65,246.87	67.8%	11.5%
	N	15	15	15	15
National Guard	Mean	11.7	$51,365.68	80.5%	28.9%
	N	19	19	19	19
Work House	Mean	14.0	$62,493.19	64.1%	40.5%
	N	16	16	16	16
Total	Mean	15.9	$52,163.36	66.0%	27.8%
	N	159	159	159	159

Statistical significance based on ANOVA with 6 degrees of freedom

***p <.1** **p < .05 ***p <.01**

DISCUSSION

- The maps show that participants in all groups are clustered in neighborhoods that have relatively high poverty and unemployment rates. The darkest shaded regions in each of the maps indicates the highest quartile of poverty and unemployment. People leaving correctional facilities were especially likely to cluster in a few twin cities neighborhoods, stretching from the North side of Minneapolis to the Frogtown neighborhood in St. Paul.
- The table shows differences across the subgroups on four characteristics (though we examined several more). We calculated ANOVA tests that show significant differences among the reentering neighborhoods in poverty rates, median household income, home ownership, and family structure.
- Participants in the mental health groups returned to neighborhoods with the lowest average poverty rate and the highest median income average. Most neighborhood inhabitants are home owners. This group also had the highest average for residents over the age of 25 with a college degree or higher, employment, and female headed households. The mental health domain had the lowest unemployment average and lowest married couple average of all seven domains.
- Likewise, foster care participants had the second lowest poverty rate out of the seven domains researched. They were most likely to return to areas with homeowners. This group had the second highest average for median income and people over 25 with a high school diploma or higher education. Homes in these neighborhoods were more likely to be headed by females.
- In addition, juvenile correctional participants had the highest average for poverty out of the seven domains, indicating disadvantaged conditions. They also had one of the lower averages for people 25 and over with high school diploma pursuing higher education. This group returned to neighborhoods with majority rental households and low median income averages.
- Chemical dependency/drug treatment participants were more likely to return to areas with married homeowners and poverty rates averaging 18%. The reentry neighborhoods had a high percentage for employment.
- The adult prison group returned to areas with female headed households. This domain had the lowest median income out of all seven averages. Majority of the inhabitants in these neighborhoods are home owners. This group had the second lowest average for married couples and residents living below poverty.
- Work house participants returned to areas with high employment, married couples, and home owner averages. This group had the highest percentage for participants over 25 with a college degrees and married couple averages.
- Participants in this study from the National Guard are more likely to return to neighborhoods with high median income, home owners, and individuals 25 and older with college degrees. They are less likely to return to areas with high unemployment. Participants typically reenter into married households.

CONCLUSION

Caution: These reentry patterns apply only to the participants in the Minnesota Exits and Entries Program (MEEP) and may not reflect the populations of the groups as a whole. Nevertheless, these patterns are instructive and help to contextualize the experiences of participants. Life course theories of crime point to the importance of job stability, family support, and secure housing in helping smooth the transition from institution to community. One of the major challenges for young people reentering after institutional care is the lack of opportunities available to them in the neighborhoods to which they return. In particular, young adults leaving the juvenile correction system are likely to return to neighborhoods with 1 in 5 households falling below the poverty level. Unfortunately, high poverty and unemployment rates are common in the census tracts we examined for almost all groups.

Background image found on www.google.com